



A Himalayan Tahr jumps across a waterfall, and a fish taking the bait

to do (and what not to do) in order to get an animal in front of your camera, and getting it done quickly."

He has more than half a dozen camera bodies, and a whole bunch of lenses. His most expensive body is a Nikon D4s, while his 400mm f2.8 costs almost as much as that camera. Much of his equipment is Nikon, although on rare assignments he has used Canon.

Some kinds of photography are particularly expensive with investment in time and money, like underwater photography – you can't just know how to swim, you need to obtain a certification in diving and also buy expensive housing (protective underwater covering) for the camera, which can cost lakhs!



Here's a green turtle amidst coral and reef fish

NO BOSSES!

"Nobody tells me to do anything – I rarely do assignments, and in most cases I plan my own travel. My strengths are my local connections and researchers, and all of that comes together to make the final image."

Mukherjee doesn't see it as a competition either. "If you take a photo that I don't have, I'm happy that the job is done. It's not about you or me, it's not about us competing. If there's a rare bird in its nest, and we all go there to shoot it, eventually the bird will abandon the nest and its eggs. How is that helping nature? All photographers and all photos are important. They cannot be compared."

WHAT'S NEXT?

Where's he going next? To the least explored places of course! Mukherjee concedes that the north east of India in Arunachal, Mizoram and parts of Nagaland haven't been well explored. Even India as a whole is relatively unexplored. Ten per cent is his guess, which means he wants to tell you the story of the remaining 90 per cent of India. He's also headed to Mexico in a few weeks.

At the end of the interview we asked him what his favourite species is. We should have known better: "I'd recommend that others don't chase the best species, the best location or the best photo. This is an unhealthy approach. All species have their own role, and you decide what to photograph based on what is documented and what isn't. This same rule works for locations as well." 📷